SCENE 004 — PRUITT

Trigger: Scene 003 end — Sheriff approaches Marcus on the main road **Time:** Early morning — town waking up around them **Location:** Main road, Wroughtwood **Incoming Flags:** PRUITT_SUSPICIOUS_LOW / PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_ATTACK / PRUITT_HOSTILE / PRUITT_UNSETTLED

NARRATION

Sheriff Ray Pruitt is not a large man but he takes up space the way certain men do — through stillness, through the particular weight of someone who has never had to raise his voice twice in the same town. Mid-forties. Broad across the shoulders. A face built for patience, the kind that wears down stone.

His badge is old. Older than him, by the look of it. You get the impression it has been in his family the way land gets passed down.

The town has gone quiet behind him. Not the quiet of people minding their business. The quiet of people watching from windows.

He looks at you the way a man looks at a ledger that doesn't balance yet.

"Ray Pruitt," he says. *"Sheriff of Wroughtwood going on eighteen years. My father held this badge before me. His father before that."* He says it without pride, without apology. Just fact. The way a man states the weather. *"This town runs a certain way. Has for a long time. I aim to keep it running that way."*

He looks at the blood on your shirt. At the torn collar. At your hands.

"Now. You want to tell me what happened to you?"

CONDITIONAL OPENING MODIFIER

> *Based on incoming flag from Scene 003:*

- **PRUITT_SUSPICIOUS_LOW** — He's already heard the accident story. He picks up here having half-decided to be patient. *Tone: measured, giving Marcus rope.*
- **PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_ATTACK** — He knows Marcus said he was attacked. His eyes have already moved to the tree line and back. *Tone: quieter, more careful.*
- **PRUITT_HOSTILE** — Marcus already gave him nothing. He's thinner on patience. *Tone: controlled but tight — one wrong answer from a decision.*
- **PRUITT_UNSETTLED** — The stare bothered him and he doesn't know why. *Tone: watchful, keeping more distance than normal. Something in him is reading Marcus as dangerous without being able to name it.*

THE CONVERSATION — Pruitt's Questions

> *Pruitt asks four questions. His tone shifts with each answer — warmer if Marcus is straight with him, colder if he senses evasion. He doesn't telegraph the shift. He just gets quieter.*

QUESTION 1 — "What's your name and where are you from?"

Response	Pruitt Reads It As	Internal Shift
Full name, straight answer	Cooperative	+1 CORDIAL
First name only	Cautious but not lying	Neutral
Fake name	*He doesn't know it's fake — but something in the delivery registers.*	-1 CORDIAL
Silence or deflection	Hiding something	-2 CORDIAL, leans toward cell

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QUESTION 2 — "What brought you out on that road last night?"

Response	Pruitt Reads It As	Internal Shift
Passing through, tells truth about job vaguely	Reasonable	+1 CORDIAL
Just driving, no destination	Suspicious — men without destinations make him nervous	-1 CORDIAL
Mentions Curtis honestly	Straightforward, gives Pruitt something to work with	+2 CORDIAL
Lies about destination	*He doesn't catch the lie yet — but files it.*	Neutral now, -2 CORDIAL later when it unravels

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QUESTION 3 — "That blood belong to you?"

> *This is the question that matters. Pruitt watches Marcus's eyes when he asks it.*

Response	Pruitt Reads It As	Internal Shift
"I don't know. I woke up and I wasn't hurt."	Strange — but honest strange. Pruitt has heard strange in this town before.	+1 CORDIAL — honesty counts even when the answer makes no sense
"Something attacked us on the road."	Gives him something to investigate. He's a lawman — he prefers a problem he can name.	+1 CORDIAL, PRUITT_INVESTIGATING_ATTACK set
"It's not mine." No elaboration.	Half an answer. He doesn't like half answers.	-1 CORDIAL
Deflects entirely	*The quiet comes down.*	-2 CORDIAL

QUESTION 4 — "You plan on causing trouble in my town?"

> *It is not quite a threat. It is a line being drawn in a language Pruitt has spoken his whole life.*

Response	Pruitt Reads It As	Internal Shift
"No sir. I just need a place to get my bearings and find my friend."	Direct. Respectful without being servile. Pruitt respects the distinction.	+2 CORDIAL
"I'm not looking for any trouble."	Acceptable. Passive.	+1 CORDIAL
"I don't start trouble."	He likes this one. Something in it sounds like him.	+2 CORDIAL, small measure of respect registered
Silence	*The quiet gets long. His hand moves to his belt.*	-2 CORDIAL
"Depends on what kind of trouble finds me."	**RAGE CHECK** — if RAGE > 30, Marcus says this with something in his voice that wasn't there before. Pruitt goes very still.	-3 CORDIAL, PRUITT_UNSETTLED upgraded to PRUITT_WARY

OUTCOME — Based on CORDIAL Score

> *CORDIAL is an internal scene-only counter. Final score determines the outcome.*

CORDIAL 5+ — "You seem straight enough."

Pruitt looks at Marcus a long moment. Then he nods — one slow movement, the kind that means a decision has been made.

"You seem straight enough," he says. *"And you look like something the road chewed up and left."*

He looks at the blood on Marcus's shirt. Looks away. Looks back.

"My boy outgrew half his wardrobe before he had the sense to stop growing. Got a bag of it in the office been meaning to take somewhere useful." He says it matter-of-factly, like it costs him nothing, like charity is a transaction he's completing efficiently. *"You can change in the jail. Nobody's using it."*

He starts walking toward the sheriff's office without waiting to see if Marcus follows.

"Miss Hattie runs the inn on this road. Clean rooms. Fair price. Tell her Pruitt sent you — she'll put your first night on my account."

He opens the door to the office. Steps aside for Marcus to enter.

"One thing," he says, before Marcus goes in. *"Everybody earns their place here. Doesn't matter who you are or where you came from. You carry your weight, you stay out of what isn't your business, you'll get along fine."* A pause. *"You don't — and I will make things very uncomfortable for you very quickly. We understand each other?"*

He extends his hand.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Take it or don't]

- **Take it:** PRUITT_REL: CORDIAL set. Stat effect: HUMANITY +5, COMPOSURE +5. *Marcus shakes the hand of a man whose family built this town on bones. He knows it. Pruitt doesn't think about it. The gap between those two things is where this relationship lives.*
- **Don't take it:** PRUITT_REL: NEUTRAL set. Stat effect: COMPOSURE -5. *Pruitt's hand drops. His face doesn't change. He goes inside. The clothes and the room are still offered — he said what he said and he means it. But the warmth, such as it was, is gone.*

CORDIAL 2–4 — "Stay visible."

Pruitt studies Marcus for a long moment.

"I'm going to give you the benefit of the doubt," he says, in the tone of a man spending something he doesn't have much of. *"But I want you visible. You eat in public. You sleep at the inn — Miss Hattie's on this road. You don't wander. You don't go near the tree line north of town."*

He steps closer. Not threatening. Establishing proximity.

"You find your friend, you come to me. You have a problem, you come to me. You do not handle things yourself in my town. Are we clear?"

No clothes. No paid room. Marcus is on his own financially. But he's free.

PRUITT_REL: WATCHED set — Pruitt keeps informal tabs on Marcus through townsfolk.

CORDIAL 1 or below — "Come with me."

The words are quiet. The hand isn't on his belt anymore — it's on Marcus's arm. Firm. Practiced.

"You're going to come with me while I sort out what happened on that road. Shouldn't take long if your story holds."

It isn't a request. It isn't quite an arrest either — Pruitt calls it *protective custody* if anyone asks. In 1960, in Wroughtwood, the difference is academic.

Marcus spends the first morning in a jail cell. He is not harmed. Pruitt is not cruel. But the cell is real and the bars are real and the town gets its first image of the stranger as a man the sheriff brought in.

PRUITT_REL: HOSTILE set. **Stat Effect:** RAGE +15, HUMANITY -5 — the cage does something to the wolf. **Side Effect:** TOWN_FIRST_IMPRESSION: CRIMINAL set — affects how NPCs treat Marcus throughout the game.

The cell smells like rust and old fear. Through the single window Marcus can see the main road and the people of Wroughtwood going about their morning like he doesn't exist. At the far edge of town where the land goes soft and dark, the swamp begins. Willow branches hang over the water like curtains drawn almost shut.

Something is standing behind them. Still. Watching the jail with the patience of something that has been patient a very long time.

By the time Marcus blinks, the willows are just willows.

SCENE NOTES

- **Pruitt extending his hand** is the scene's moral weight. It is a genuine gesture from a man who considers himself fair — and it asks Marcus to shake the hand of a legacy. Taking it is pragmatic. Not taking it is principled. Neither is wrong. The game doesn't judge it.
- **"Everybody earns their place here"** is Pruitt's personal code. He applies it consistently — which is both his decency and his blindness. The town was built on land that was taken, not earned. He has never examined that contradiction.
- **The cell scene** introduces Marie Veau visually for the first time even in the worst outcome — she's watching. She already knows.
- **PRUITT_INVESTIGATING_ATTACK** flag means Pruitt sends someone to check the road. They'll find the car. They'll find the carcass in the tree line eventually. What they make of it depends on how much the town's history has prepared them.
- **Pruitt's family line** — grandfather helped drive the natives off the sacred land. This is background for now. It becomes foreground when the land's history fully surfaces.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
PRUITT_REL	Set to CORDIAL / WATCHED / HOSTILE based on outcome
PRUITT_INVESTIGATING_ATTACK	Question 3, attack response
PRUITT_WARY	Question 4, rage-check response
TOWN_FIRST_IMPRESSION	Set to FREE or CRIMINAL based on outcome
HATTIE_NAME_KNOWN	CORDIAL or WATCHED outcome
MARIE_FIRST_SIGHTING	HOSTILE outcome — seen from cell window
CLOTHES_RECEIVED	CORDIAL outcome only
FIRST_NIGHT_PAID	CORDIAL outcome only

LEADS TO

Outcome	Next Scene
CORDIAL	**SCENE 005A — THE INN** Marcus walks in clean, paid for, with Pruitt's name behind him. The town watches a man who apparently passed the sheriff's test.
WATCHED	**SCENE 005B — THE INN (CONDITIONAL)** Marcus arrives on his own terms but under scrutiny. Hattie gives him a room — he pays himself. The town's read on him is unclear.
HOSTILE	**SCENE 005C — THE CELL** Marcus spends the morning locked up. Released by midday when Pruitt's story checks out. Walks into town already carrying a reputation.